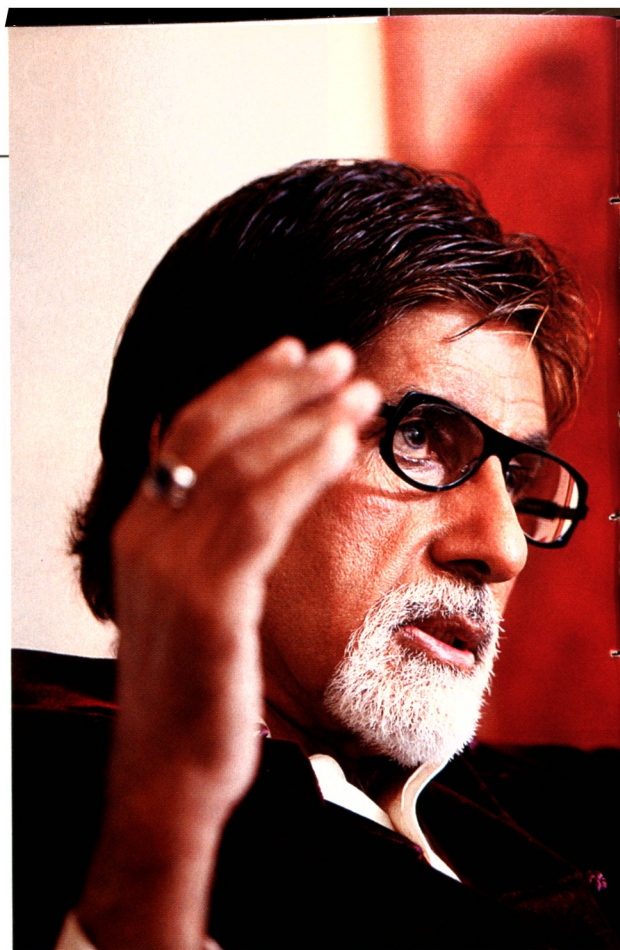


cinema THE BACHCHANS

work on their films. Coming up for Aishwarya and Abhishek will be another Mani Ratnam film, their sixth together, "the most we've done with any co-star", points out Aishwarya. Individually, Abhishek has two releases this year—the special effects Rs 100-crore adventure *Drona* and the Rs 30-crore drama *Dilli 6*. Aishwarya, the highest paid woman actor at Rs 4 crore, is preparing for Shankar's *Robot*, opposite Rajnikant, while Amitabh will be seeing the release of the fantasy film, *Aladdin*, *Shoebite* and Leena Yadav's *Teen Patti*.

They are so involved in their careers that shooting for *Sarkar Raj* during a 40-day stint in Hyderabad's Ramoji Film City last year, immediately after a honeymoon in Tahiti, was the first time in 10 years that Abhishek spent uninterrupted time with his father. They would have lunch together daily in Amitabh's trailer and then get back to being antagonists on the sets. They were then joined by Jaya, the matriarch who is their unofficial restrainer—she will check any shop talk on the dining table with as much thoroughness as she will choose the paintings to be hung in every room—for a visit to Srisailem, one of the country's 12 Jyotirlinga Shiva shrines.

Ah, temples, just one of the many controversies that seems to have attached itself like a limpet to the Bachchan name. There are several others, and as the Bachchans sit down on plush leather sofas, flanked by a painting by Pritish Nandy—which appropriately, given Amitabh's writerly mood, has words splattered all across the canvas—they talk about themselves at length. Amitabh is trying to fix his phone, and his son jumps to his aid. "He's into computers, mobiles are my domain," says Abhishek, "we multitask as a family." Excerpts from the conversation, which in keeping



"We're all professionals. But to look at us as a big mafia family that sits, designs and operates the brand is nonsense."

"I am not against the media. We

IF THERE IS A CALLOUS REMARK, IF THERE IS DISINFORMATION, IF THERE IS UNWANTED QUESTIONING, WOULD YOU CALL IT HITTING BACK?

with Amitabh's new-found distrust of the media, is being videographed and documented by a team of two.

Q. So what's the collective box-office of this family?

Abhishek (AB Jr). Mine is currently zero this year because I haven't had any releases.

Q. I mean of all time.

AB Jr. Pa alone is over Rs 3,000 crore. Here, I'll tell you where to find that figure.

Aishwarya. (Laughing). She knows. She's already checked it out.

AB Jr. She's also in the all-time top 10 list. (She's not. She's ranked 29 among the top-grossing women).

Q. And what about you, Abhishek?

"Everybody goes to temples. There's no question of who is coming or who is not coming."

AB Jr. I'm 7,500. (He's not. He's ranked 28 among the men).

Q. How was it being in a film, so soon after the wedding, where all of you are antagonists and Aishwarya comes between the father and son?

Aishwarya. This sounds like a prepared answer but the truth is when the camera rolls and you're there on the sets, saying your lines, that's what you're doing. We have worked with each other even before. The two of us have done maximum films with each other as co-actors. It's about being the